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DPO-803-E
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Luis Arrese (C): Holidays

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Luis' most vivid memories of the time he spent in the United States were of the periods of solitude, homesickness and sadness, the long telephone conversations, the hours spent on airplanes (usually, when he flew back to Valencia, he spent more time on the plane than with his family).

Also, although he did not perhaps fully acknowledge it, he could not help feeling slightly guilty when he thought how difficult it had been for his wife to keep the business going on her own, while running the home and bringing up the children.

Three incidents in particular stood out in his mind:

The first was before he moved to the United States. Luis sat down with his son Carlos to explain that he was going far away to work and that he would come and visit him every few weeks. Looking him in the eye, Carlos interrupted: "Are you telling me the truth, Dad? There are boys at school whose fathers have separated from their mothers. Are you going to separate from Mum?" Luis was aghast. He and his wife spent the next two hours sitting with Carlos, explaining that everything was perfectly all right between them, that there was no problem in their marriage and that it was just a question of Luis' job. Eventually Carlos was convinced, but Luis slept badly that night.

The second incident was during one of Luis' visits to his family. His daughter, Laura, was playing with one of those books that show small children how to recognize objects and say what they are called. Seeing a brightly colored picture of a house, the girl pointed with her little finger and, very pleased with herself, turned to her mother and said "house". To everybody's delight, she went on pointing and naming things. Then she came to a pretty red telephone and, eyes shining, said proudly: "Daddy". Luis did not sleep well that night either.

This case was prepared by Francisco Gay, former collaborator, and Dr. Alberto Ribera, under the supervision of Professor José Ramón Pin Arboledas. February 2023.
This case is based on the case "Fernando Ruiz (C): Family Issues", DPO-65-E, by the same authors.
IESE cases are designed to promote class discussion rather than to illustrate effective or ineffective management of a given situation.

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The third incident was during another of his visits to Valencia. Luis, Ana and Laura were playing in the parents' bedroom. In the middle of their game, Ana asked the little girl: "Where's Daddy?" Laura smiled. She looked at her father and then turned to point to the photo on the bedside table. Luis later joked sarcastically: "At least the photo was of me." Luis spent several hours that night on the balcony.

Summer Holidays 2017

Although "officially" Luis had returned home, the Italian project had kept him away from home most of the time. He was only ever back at weekends, and although that was already a big improvement on the way things had been before, it was still not a normal family life, whatever that might mean.

That was made painfully clear during the family summer holiday, although Luis and Ana had already noticed that something was wrong earlier. Some weekends, when Luis came back from the United States, it was obvious something was jarring. Somehow, everyone was on edge.

Ana had grown accustomed to handling everything herself: timetables, discipline, permissible behavior, TV remote, etc.

Luis had had no experience of family life for almost two years. He had got used to deciding everything himself. He had lost the habit of living with other people and communicating with small children. And needless to say, he knew best how to handle the TV remote.

They had been warned that such "friction" would be fairly mild if it was just a weekend, but that the real problems would start when he came to live with his family for longer periods. And that is precisely what happened, suddenly, in those two weeks in the summer of 2017. On three occasions after starting their holiday they were on the point of canceling it and going back home on account of the frequent rows between Ana and Luis about how to deal with the children, how to adapt to a family routine dictated by small children, how to share authority and how to exercise it, etc.

While the children were asleep, Luis and Ana analyzed the situation and agreed on an "action plan" to save the holiday and family harmony. Their marriage was built on solid foundations. There was no serious problem, in form or substance, either in their relationship or in the family. "All they had to do" was rebuild the habits of family life and… start over!

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